

Poker Strategy

Pre Flop Strategy 1

Assumptions

1. Folded to me (Meaning no Limp or raising)
2. Gear 1 (40+ BB)
3. In Position (EP, MP, LP)

Early Position

1. **Pairs:** 77 or higher
2. **Suited Aces:** ATs or higher
3. **Offsuit Aces:** AQo or higher
4. **Suited Kings:** KJs or higher
5. **Offsuit Kings:** Fold
6. **Suited Queens:** QJs
7. **Offsuit Queens:** Fold
8. **Suited Jacks:** Fold
9. **Offsuit Jacks:** Fold
10. **Connectors and Gappers:** Fold

Middle Position

1. **Pairs:** 55 or higher
2. **Suited Aces:** A8s or higher (*plus A4s-A5s*)
3. **Offsuit Aces:** AJo or higher
4. **Suited Kings:** KTs or higher
5. **Offsuit Kings:** KQo
6. **Suited Queens:** QTs or higher
7. **Offsuit Queens:** Fold
8. **Suited Jacks:** JTs
9. **Offsuit Jacks:** Fold
10. **Connectors and Gappers:** T9s and 98s

Late Position

1. **Pairs:** 22 or higher (*All pairs*)
2. **Suited Aces:** A2s or higher (*All suited Aces*)
3. **Offsuit Aces:** ATo or higher (CO) // A2o or higher (BTN)
4. **Suited Kings:** K8s or higher (CO) // K2s or higher (BTN)
5. **Offsuit Kings:** KJo or higher (CO) // K9o or higher (BTN)
6. **Suited Queens:** Q9s or higher (CO) // Q5s or higher (BTN)
7. **Offsuit Queens:** QJo (CO) // QTo or higher (BTN)
8. **Suited Jacks:** J9s or higher (CO) // J7s or higher (BTN)
9. **Offsuit Jacks:** Fold (CO) // JTo (BTN)
10. **Connectors and Gappers:** 76s or higher (CO) // 54s or higher (BTN)

How Betting Changes my Anchor

Scenario 1: The Table Folds to You (You are First In)

If you look down, check your position, and your hand meets the Anchor requirements from the range sheet, you enter the pot.

- **The Rule:** Open-Raise. Never, ever just call the Big Blind (limping).
- **The Sizing:** 2.5x to 3x the Big Blind.

Scenario 2: Players Limped Before You

One or two guys just called the minimum Big Blind because they want to "see a cheap flop." You are going to punish them for it.

- **The Rule:** The Isolation (Iso) Raise. If your hand meets the Anchor for your position, you raise to force them out or make them pay a premium to see the flop.
- **The Sizing:** 3x BB + 1x for every limper.

Now what is the anchor in this position? Determined by Performing the Stress Test

The Stress Test (What gets instantly downgraded)

If you hold any of the following assets, they are immediately stripped of their "raise" authorization.

1. All Weak Ofsuit Aces (A-2 through A-9 offsuit): Throw them in the trash. They are easily dominated and play terribly in multi-way pots.
2. All Marginal Ofsuit Broadways (K-T, Q-J, K-9 offsuit): Trash. Same logic. You will hit a pair and lose your stack to a better kicker.
3. Small Pocket Pairs (2-2 through 8-8): You do not execute a massive 6x Iso-raise with small pairs. Their only value is hitting a set. (You are allowed to just *call* the 100-chip blind to see a cheap flop with these, but you do not bloat the pot).

The "Do Not Play" Ofsuit Broadway List (Against Limpers)

- **A-T offsuit** (Ace-Ten) - *You are dominated by A-J, A-Q, and A-K.*
- **K-J offsuit** (King-Jack) - *You are dominated by K-Q, A-K, A-J.*
- **K-T offsuit** (King-Ten) - *You are dominated by K-Q, K-J, A-K, A-T.*
- **Q-J offsuit** (Queen-Jack) - *You are dominated by A-Q, K-Q, A-J, K-J.*
- **Q-T offsuit** (Queen-Ten) - *You are dominated by A-Q, K-Q, A-T, J-T.*

- **J-T offsuit** (Jack-Ten) - *Looks pretty, plays terribly offsuit.*
- **K-9 offsuit / Q-9 offsuit**

Scenario 3: Someone Raised Before You

- **With Premium Value (QQ, KK, AA, AK):** * **Action:** 3-Bet.
 - **Sizing:** 3x their raise. (e.g., They raise to 30, you make it 90).
- **With Speculative Hands (Pairs 22-JJ, Suited Connectors, Suited Broadways, AQo):** * **Action:** Flat-Call.
- **With Marginal Trash (AJo, KQo, low suited Aces):**
 - **Action:** Fold. Do not get trapped calling raises with easily dominated offsuit cards.

The Concrete Solution: The Dynamic Squeeze Formula

When you hold Premium Value (AA, KK, QQ, AK) and face a raise with multiple callers, this is your new, concrete checklist:

Step 1: Calculate the Squeeze Size

Take the original raise and multiply it by 3.

Add the size of the raise for every single player who called.

(Example: 100 raise + 4 callers = 300 + 400 = 700 Squeeze Size).

Step 2: The SPR (Stack-to-Pot Ratio) Commitment Check

Look at the Squeeze Size you just calculated (700) and compare it to your total stack (1,990).

The Concrete Threshold: If the required Squeeze Size equals 30% or more of your total stack, you do not raise to that number. You instantly shove All-In.

When you are set-mining with hands like 22 through 88, you are banking entirely on Implied Odds—the massive future payout you expect to collect if you hit your set. Because you only hit a set on the flop about 12% of the time (roughly 1 in 8 times), the math dictates that the potential reward must far outweigh the pre-flop cost.

To figure out exactly how much of your capital you are allowed to allocate to a pre-flop call, you use The Rule of 15.

 The Rule of 15 (The Set-Mining Threshold)

Before you flat-call a raise with a small-to-medium pocket pair, you must look at the Effective Stack Size (the smaller of either your stack or the raiser's stack).

The Rule: You can only call a raise if the effective stack is at least 10 to 15 times larger than the amount you have to call.

If the potential payout isn't at least 10x to 15x the price of admission, the investment has a negative expected value (-EV) and you must fold.

When facing a raise, your authorization to flat-call with anything less than a God-Tier asset is completely dictated by stack depth:

Need 10x to 12x the call amount: For Pocket Pairs (99-JJ) to set-mine.

Need 15x the call amount: For Suited Broadways and Suited Connectors.

Scenario 4: Pre-Flop All-In Protocol

40+ BB Stacks

1. Facing a Massive All-In

- a) Holding AA or KK? → Snap Call.

- b) Holding QQ or AK?
 - Against a loose/aggressive opponent → Call.
 - Against a tight or unknown opponent → Fold and preserve capital.
- c) Holding JJ, TT, AQ, or any weaker hand? → Snap Fold.

Rule: At 40+ BB, pre-flop all-ins are decided by equity. Unless you hold the very top of your range, avoid risking your entire stack.

2. Initiating a 5-Bet All-In

- a) AA or KK → Always Shove.
- b) AK → Shove only when Out of Position to maximize fold equity.
- c) Any other hand → Do Not Shove.

Rule: Shoving with anything weaker than this turns premium hands into unnecessary gambles.
Short-Stack Override (<20 BB)

Small Blind

1. **Pairs:** 99 or higher (*3-Bet*)
2. **Suited Aces:** AJs or higher (*3-Bet Value*), A2s-A5s (*3-Bet Bluff*)
3. **Offsuit Aces:** AQo or higher (*3-Bet*)
4. **Suited Kings:** KQs (*3-Bet Value*), K9s (*3-Bet Bluff*)
5. **Offsuit Kings:** Fold
6. **Suited Queens:** Fold
7. **Offsuit Queens:** Fold
8. **Suited Jacks:** Fold
9. **Offsuit Jacks:** Fold
10. **Connectors and Gappers:** Fold

Scenario 5: Someone Raised Before You (You are in the SMALL BLIND)

You are in the worst position in poker. You will act first post-flop.

- **The Rule:** 3-Bet or Fold. You completely remove flat-calling from your playbook here.
- **With Premium Value (JJ+, AK, AQs):**
 - **Action:** 3-Bet.
 - **Sizing:** 4x their raise. (The OOP Tax. Make it massive so they fold their steals, or you build a giant pot with a premium hand).
- **Everything Else (Small pairs, connectors, weak Aces):**
 - **Action:** Fold. Don't bleed chips trying to hit a set out of position against a pre-flop raiser.

Big Blind

THE BIG BLIND (BB) vs. EARLY POSITION

Rule: Respect the UTG raiser. Defend tightly.

1. **Pairs:** 22-JJ (*Flat Call*) // QQ or higher (*3-Bet*)
2. **Suited Aces:** ATs-AQs (*Flat Call*) // AKs (*3-Bet*)
3. **Offsuit Aces:** Fold ATo/AJo // AQo-AKo (*3-Bet*)
4. **Suited Kings:** KQs (*Flat Call*)
5. **Offsuit Kings:** Fold
6. **Suited Queens:** Fold
7. **Offsuit Queens:** Fold
8. **Suited Jacks:** JTs (*Flat Call*)
9. **Offsuit Jacks:** Fold
10. **Connectors and Gappers:** T9s, 98s, 87s (*Flat Call*)

THE BIG BLIND (BB) vs. LATE POSITION

Rule: The Button is stealing. Defend widely.

1. **Pairs:** 22-TT (*Flat Call*) // JJ or higher (*3-Bet*)
2. **Suited Aces:** A2s-AJs (*Flat Call*) // AQs+ and A2s-A5s (*3-Bet*)
3. **Offsuit Aces:** A2o-AQo (*Flat Call*) // AKo (*3-Bet*)
4. **Suited Kings:** K2s-KTs (*Flat Call*) // KQs, K9s, K8s (*3-Bet*)
5. **Offsuit Kings:** KTo or higher (*Flat Call*)
6. **Suited Queens:** Q2s or higher (*Flat Call*)
7. **Offsuit Queens:** QJo or higher (*Flat Call*)
8. **Suited Jacks:** J2s or higher (*Flat Call*)
9. **Offsuit Jacks:** JTo (*Flat Call*)
10. **Connectors and Gappers:** 54s or higher (*Flat Call*) // T9s (*3-Bet Bluff*)

Playing Gappers (Only Play Late Position)

Before looking at position, you must filter the asset itself:

One-Gappers (e.g., J9s, T8s, 97s, 86s): Authorized for situational evaluation.

The Positional Matrix (Unopened Pots)

When the action folds to you, here is how you treat Suited One-Gappers:

Early Position (UTG, UTG+1) & Middle Position:

Action: Snap Fold.

Late Position (Cutoff & Button):

Action: Open-Raise (2.5x BB).

The Betting Matrix (Facing Market Action)

Scenario A: Facing Limpers (Dead Money)

In Late Position (Button/Cutoff):

Action: You are authorized to Limp Behind (Overcall) only if there are 2 or more limpers already in the pot, giving you massive immediate pot odds.

Scenario B: Facing a Raise (The Rule of 20)

Because Suited One-Gappers make straights significantly less often than pure Suited Connectors, the Rule of 15 is not enough protection. You must upgrade the multiplier.
Action Limit: The Rule of 20.

Post Flop Strategy

STEP 1: The Pre-Action Audit (The 5-Second Check)

Do this the absolute second the flop hits, before anyone acts.

1. Calculate SPR (Stack-to-Pot Ratio): $\text{Effective Stack Size} / \text{Current Pot Size}$

This dictates your risk threshold and willingness to go bankrupt in this hand.

- **SPR 0 to 3 (Committed):** You are financially tied to this pot. If you hit Top Pair with a good kicker, you are going all-in. No folding, no pot control.
- **SPR 4 to 8 (The Danger Zone):** You have enough chips to maneuver. A single Top Pair is for *pot control*. You only play for your entire stack if you have Two Pair or better.
- **SPR 9+ (Deep Water):** You are deep-stacked. You need an absolute premium monster (Set, Nut Flush, etc.) to play for all your chips.

2. Audit the Board Texture:

- **Dry (Static):** e.g., K-8-2 rainbow. Few draws exist. The best hand now is likely the best hand later.
- **Wet (Dynamic):** e.g., J♠-T♠-9♦. A minefield of straight and flush draws. Board equities will change drastically on the turn.

STEP 2: Hand Value Classification (The "What Beats Me?" Test)

Brutally categorize your actual hand strength in relation to the board.

- **Premium:** Sets, Straights, Flushes, strong Top Two Pair. (Almost nothing beats you).
- **Showdown:** Top Pair, Middle Pair, Overpair. (A pure bluff-catcher. Vulnerable).
- **Strong Draw:** Flush Draw, Open-Ended Straight Draw. (High math probability to hit the nuts).
- **Air:** Missed completely. Ace-high or worse. (Dead asset)

STEP 3: The Execution Matrix (When you are first to act)

Your Hand Value	On a DRY Board (e.g., K-8-2 rainbow)	On a WET Board (e.g., J-T-9 w/ flush draw)
Premium (Set, Two Pair+)	Bet Small (33% pot). Keep them in the hand. You want them to call with worse.	Bet Big (75% - 100% pot). Charge the maximum penalty for their draws.
Showdown (Top/Mid Pair)	Check or Bet Small (33% pot). Get to showdown cheaply (Pot Control).	Check/Call. Do not build a massive pot with one pair when draws are everywhere.
Strong Draw (Flush/OESD)	<i>N/A (Dry boards don't have these)</i>	Bet/Raise (66% pot). Play aggressively as a semi-bluff to force weak pairs to fold.
Air (Missed completely)	Check / Fold. Abort the hand.	Check / Fold. Abort the hand.

Note 1 : **Calling Threshold Protocol** for exactly how much capital you are allowed to risk when holding a single pair (Top or Middle Pair) on a wet, dynamic board.

The "Wet Board / Single Pair" Calling Limits

When your opponent bets into you, you measure their bet size against the current pot to determine your action:

1. The "Cheap Price" (Under 33% of the Pot)

- **The Action: Call immediately.**
- **The Logic:** If the pot is 1,000 and they bet 250, they are giving you incredible mathematical pot odds. Your pair is too strong to fold for such a small penalty, and they might just be testing the waters with a weak draw or a worse pair.

2. The "Standard Bet" (50% to 66% of the Pot)

- **The Action: Call (but proceed with extreme caution).**
- **The Logic:** This is the absolute limit of what you should pay to see the turn. You call this bet on the flop because your Top Pair *might* still be the best hand, but you are not happy about it. You are essentially paying the toll to see if the turn card is a blank.

3. The "Heavy Bet / Overbet" (75% to 100%+ of the Pot)

- **The Action: Snap Fold.**
- **The Logic:** If the pot is 1,000 and they fire 800 or 1,000 on a wet board, your single pair is dead. They are telling you they either already hit the nuts (a set or two pair), or they have a massive combo-draw that actually has more mathematical equity than your pair. Do not pay a premium price with a vulnerable asset. Let it go.

Note 2 : Rule for Multi-Way Pots (3 or more players post-flop)

1. Bluffing Authorization = Zero As we just established, your semi-bluffs and pure bluffs are completely revoked. You do not throw chips at three people hoping they all missed. You Check/Call your strong draws purely based on the pot odds (using the No-Math Price Limit Matrix), but you do not drive the action.

2. The Single Pair Depreciation (The Downgrade) In a Heads-Up pot, Top Pair with a great kicker (like holding A-K on a K-7-2 board) is often treated as a Premium Asset. You can value bet it aggressively. In a **Multi-Way pot**, a single pair—even Top Pair with the best kicker—is automatically downgraded to **Showdown Value (A Bluff-Catcher)**.

- **The Logic:** If you bet Top Pair into three people and get called, or worse, raised, you are almost always losing to two-pair, a set, or a massive combo-draw. The market is too crowded to trust one pair.
- **The Action:** You shift to strict pot-control. You Check. If you do bet, you bet small (25% to 33% pot) strictly to charge draws, but you are prepared to fold instantly if someone raises you. You only play for massive stacks in multi-way pots if you have Two Pair, a Set, or better.

The Execution Matrix when you are not first to Act

Your Hand Value	Flop Max Price (2 cards to come)	Turn Max Price (1 card to come)
Strong Draw (Flush or Open-Ended Straight)	Call up to 75% of the Pot.	Call up to 50% of the Pot.

Weak Draw (Gutshot / Inside Straight)	Call up to 25% of the Pot. (Fold to anything bigger).	Fold. (Do not pay to chase 4 cards).
Showdown Value (Top Pair / Middle Pair)	Call up to 50% of the Pot. (Pot control).	Call up to 33% of the Pot. (Proceed with extreme caution).
Air (Missed completely / Bottom Pair)	Fold. (Zero capital allocation).	Fold.

Your Hand Value Flop Action (Facing a Bet) The Financial Logic

Premium (Two Pair, Set+) Raise (2.5x to 3x their bet) Seize pricing control. Force draws to pay a massive, unprofitable premium to see the next card.

Note 1

This is the exact moment the alarm bells should be ringing. When you execute a 2.5x to 3x value raise on the flop or turn and the opponent comes back over the top with another re-raise (a 3-bet or a shove), the entire dynamic of the hand collapses into a very narrow, high-stakes decision.

A re-raise over your raise is the ultimate display of market strength. Their range of "Top Pair" and "Overpairs" generally evaporates here—they either have the God-Tier nuts (a Set or a Better Two Pair) or a massive, high-equity Combo Draw.

Here is your exact systematic checklist to determine whether you call off your stack or fold your Two Pair.

1. The Board Texture Audit (Wet vs. Dry)

The texture of the board dictates everything about their re-raising range.

The Dry Board (No obvious draws): If the board is [K, 8, 3] rainbow and you hold K-8 for Top Two Pair, and they re-raise you—Fold. On a dry board, there are no draws to bluff with. A re-raise here means one thing: they have a Set of 8s or a Set of 3s, and you are drawing functionally dead. Swallow your pride and preserve your capital.

The Wet Board (Heavy draws possible): If the board is [J, 9, 4] with two hearts, their re-raise range expands drastically. Aggressive players will often shove all-in with a massive Combo Draw (e.g., Qh-10h giving them an open-ended straight draw and a flush draw). Against Combo Draws, your Two Pair is mathematically ahead, and you must Call.

2. The Asset Quality Check (Top Two vs. Bottom Two)

Not all Two Pairs are created equal. You must audit exactly which Two Pair you hold before committing your tournament life.

Top Two Pair (Holding J-9 on J-9-4): This is a true premium asset. You block their ability to have a Set of Jacks or Nines. If the board is wet, you close your eyes, make the call, and accept the variance.

Bottom Two Pair (Holding 9-4 on J-9-4): This is highly toxic when facing a re-raise. You are crushed by a Set, but you are also completely crushed by Top Two Pair (J-9). Furthermore, any Jack or higher card on the turn or river counterfeits your hand. When facing a massive re-raise, Bottom Two Pair is a mandatory fold.

Turn Strategy

The Turn Matrix (The Pivot)

Your Hand Value	If a BLANK Card Hits	If a SCARY Card Hits
Premium (Two Pair, Set+)	Bet Big (66% - 75% pot). Fire the "double barrel." Capitalize on your asset while the board is safe.	Audit the Damage. Did that card beat you? If you still have the absolute nuts, bet. If your two-pair is suddenly losing to a flush, shift to Check .
Showdown (Top/Mid Pair)	Check. Exercise strict pot control. Do not bloat the pot out of position with a single pair.	Check. Your pair is now heavily depreciated. Prepare to fold if they bet heavy.
Strong Draw (Flush/OESD)	Bet (50% - 66% pot). Keep up the semi-bluff. Force them to make a tough decision while you still have equity.	Check / Call (if cheap). If the scary card didn't hit <i>your</i> draw, slow down and check.

Air (Missed completely)	Check / Fold. The bluff failed on the flop. Abort the operation.	Check / Fold. Stop bleeding chips.
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River Strategy

The River Matrix (The End Game)

The River is beautiful because the chaos of draws is completely gone. The board is locked. You either have the best hand, or you don't.

Because the math is now totally binary, your betting strategy must also be binary. When acting first, you execute one of these strict protocols:

Your Final Hand Value	The Action	The Financial Logic
Premium / The Nuts	Value Bet (50% - 75% pot).	You want to extract the maximum amount a worse hand (like a stubborn Top Pair) is willing to pay. <i>Never check the nuts when acting first unless you are 100% certain the opponent will bluff.</i>
Showdown (Top/Mid Pair)	Check.	Never value bet a marginal hand on the river. If you bet, worse hands just fold, and hands that beat you will call or raise. By checking, you induce your opponent to bluff with their missed draws.
Air (Missed Draw)	Check / Fold.	(Standard Procedure). The asset is dead. Write it off and surrender the pot.

Air (The Pure Bluff)	Overbet (75% - 100%+ pot).	(High-Risk Procedure). Only execute this if a terrifying card hit the river (like completing a flush) and you know you cannot win a showdown. You must bet heavy to force them off a single pair.
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The River Matrix: Final Capital Deployment

Calling on the river requires absolute discipline because the math changes entirely. There are no more cards to come. Implied odds are dead. You are no longer paying for potential—you are paying for an immediate, mathematical showdown.

Here are the strict thresholds for calling a bet on the final street:

1. Holding "Air" (Missed Draws / High Cards)

The Mandate: Fold.

The Logic: The asset is dead. Write it off and surrender the pot. You are authorized to check in the hopes they check behind, but you are strictly forbidden from paying a "curiosity tax" to see their cards if they bet.

2. Holding "Showdown Value" (Top Pair / Middle Pair)

This is where capital leaks happen the most. A single pair is merely a bluff-catcher on the river. Facing a Heavy Bet (75% to 100%+ of the pot): Snap Fold. The system absolutely prohibits paying off massive river bets with a single pair.

Facing a Small Bet (Under 50% pot): You are authorized to call, provided the board didn't just complete an obvious straight or flush.

Narrative Check

The Triple Barrel: If the opponent bet the flop, bet the turn, and is now betting the river, they are telling a consistent story of massive strength. A single pair almost never beats a player firing on all three streets. Fold.

The Sudden Wake-Up: If the opponent checked the flop, checked the turn, and suddenly fired a bet on the river, their story does not make sense. This is the classic signature of a player with a missed draw trying to steal the pot at the last second. Call.

3. Holding "Premium / The Nuts" (Top Two Pair, Sets, or Better)

The Mandate: Raise (Value Extraction) or Call (Damage Control).

The Logic: Never forget that Top Two Pair is a Premium Asset, not a bluff-catcher. If an opponent bets into you on a safe, dry board, you must raise.

The Scary Card Override:

When the board texture shifts from "safe" to "scary" (e.g., a third or fourth flush card drops, or a four-card straight connects), your Two Pair or Three of a Kind are instantly stripped of their "Premium" status.

The system automatically downgrades them to Showdown Value (A Bluff-Catcher). Because it is now just a Bluff-Catcher, you must apply the strict Showdown Value limits to your river decision.